SOUTH INDIAN COLLECTION

NO. 02



KARNATAKA ORIGIN — MYSORE

Bisibele Bath

Spiced Rice, Lentil & Vegetable One-Pot
Karnataka's Royal Comfort Food

AUTHENTIC RECIPE · STEP-BY-STEP GUIDE · PRINTABLE DIGITAL COOKBOOK

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Bisibele Bath

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ABOUT THIS BOOK

Bisibele Bath

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Nutrition values are estimates. Cooking times vary with equipment and ingredients. Readers with allergies or dietary restrictions should check every ingredient label before cooking.

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THE STORY BEHIND THE DISH

From Palace Kitchens to Everyday Comfort

"Bisi bele bath" translates directly from Kannada as "hot lentil rice," a name that undersells just how complex this dish actually is — a single-pot combination of rice, toor dal, mixed vegetables, tamarind, and a distinctive roasted spice powder that sets it apart from other South Indian rice preparations. The dish is closely associated with Mysore, and food tradition credits its refinement to the kitchens of the Mysore Palace, where Iyengar Brahmin cooks are said to have developed the specific spice blend that gives bisibele bath its recognizable character.

What distinguishes bisibele bath from a simple sambar rice is its dedicated masala — a roasted blend of dried red chilies, coriander seeds, cinnamon, cloves, and other warming spices, often including a touch of poppy seed or desiccated coconut for body, ground specifically for this dish rather than borrowed from a general sambar powder. This distinct spice profile gives bisibele bath a warmth and depth that has made it one of Karnataka's most recognized culinary exports.

Today it's a staple at Karnataka festivals, wedding menus, and everyday family lunches alike, often finished with a generous drizzle of ghee and a scattering of fried cashews — a final touch that elevates the dish from simple comfort food to something worth serving guests.

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THE STORY BEHIND THE DISH

From Palace Kitchens to Everyday Comfort, continued

CULTURAL NOTES & OCCASIONS

Closely associated with Mysore and, by tradition, the kitchens of the Mysore Palace, where Iyengar Brahmin cooks are credited with refining the dish. Distinguished from sambar rice by its dedicated bisibele bath spice powder, roasted specifically for this dish. A staple at Karnataka festivals, weddings, and everyday family lunches, spanning both celebratory and daily cooking. Traditionally finished with ghee and fried cashews, a garnish that signals a more special, generous preparation.

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AT A GLANCE

Equipment & preparation

20m	40m	6	Med
ACTIVE PREP	COOK TIME	SERVINGS	DIFFICULTY

Recommended equipment

- Pressure cooker
- Small pan, for roasting the spice blend
- Spice grinder
- Wide pot, for the final assembly

STORAGE & MAKE-AHEAD

Bisibele bath keeps refrigerated for up to 3 days, though it thickens considerably as it cools — reheat with a generous splash of water, stirring to loosen. It freezes reasonably well for up to a month.

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WHAT YOU'LL NEED

Ingredients

For the rice and dal

INGREDIENT	US	METRIC	INDIAN
Rice (any short-grain variety)	1 cup	200 g	1 katori
Toor dal (split pigeon pea)	½ cup	100 g	½ katori
Water, for cooking	4 cups	1 L	4 katori
Turmeric powder	½ tsp	1.5 g	½ chammach

For the vegetables & tamarind

INGREDIENT	US	METRIC	INDIAN
Tamarind, seedless	2 tbsp	30 g	small lemon-size ball
Carrot, diced	½ cup	60 g	½ katori
Green beans, cut	½ cup	50 g	½ katori
Potato, diced	½ cup	80 g	½ katori
Peas, fresh or frozen	½ cup	70 g	½ katori
Small onion (shallots), sliced	8–10	80 g	8–10

For the bisibele bath powder (or 3 tbsp store-bought)

INGREDIENT	US	METRIC	INDIAN
Coriander seeds	2 tbsp	12 g	2 tbsp
Chana dal	1 tbsp	12 g	1 tbsp

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WHAT YOU'LL NEED

Ingredients, continued

For the bisibele bath powder (or 3 tbsp store-bought) (cont.)

INGREDIENT	US	METRIC	INDIAN
Urad dal	1 tbsp	10 g	1 tbsp
Dried red chilies	5–6	5–6	5–6
Cinnamon stick	1 inch	1 inch	1 inch
Cloves	3	3	3
Desiccated coconut	2 tbsp	12 g	2 tbsp

For the tempering & finish

INGREDIENT	US	METRIC	INDIAN
Ghee	3 tbsp	45 g	3 chammach
Mustard seeds	1 tsp	4 g	1 chammach
Curry leaves	2 sprigs	15–20 leaves	2 sprigs
Asafoetida (hing)	pinch	pinch	chutki bhar
Cashews, for garnish	3 tbsp	35 g	3 chammach
Jaggery	1 tsp	5 g	1 chammach
Salt	1½ tsp	9 g	to taste

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WHAT YOU'LL NEED

Ingredients, continued

SUBSTITUTIONS & SOURCING

A good store-bought "bisibele bath powder," sold specifically under that name by South Indian spice brands like MTR, is a very acceptable substitute for making the blend from scratch. Any combination of vegetables works reasonably well beyond what's listed; the dish is traditionally flexible based on what's seasonally available. Short-grain rice like sona masoori is traditional, though any short or medium-grain rice works.

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STEP BY STEP · PART ONE

The Spice Powder and Base

01 ROAST AND GRIND THE SPICE BLEND

Dry roast the coriander seeds, chana dal, urad dal, dried chilies, cinnamon, cloves, and coconut in a pan until fragrant and golden, about 4–5 minutes. Cool completely, then grind to a fine powder.

Chef tip. roast until fragrant but not dark brown — over-roasting turns the powder bitter.

02 COOK THE RICE AND DAL TOGETHER

Rinse the rice and toor dal together and pressure cook with water and turmeric for 4–5 whistles, until both are very soft and slightly mushy — softer than you'd typically cook rice on its own.

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The Spice Powder and Base, continued



03 PREPARE THE TAMARIND EXTRACT

Soak the tamarind in 1 cup / 240 ml warm water for 15 minutes, then squeeze and strain to extract the pulp.

> **COOKING CHECKPOINT**
>
> The rice and dal should cook down softer than usual, almost porridge-like — this softer texture is intentional and characteristic of bisibele bath.

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STEP BY STEP · PART TWO

Bringing It All Together

04 COOK THE VEGETABLES

In a separate pot, cook the carrot, beans, potato, peas, and onion in the tamarind extract with a little water until just tender, about 10 minutes.

05 COMBINE EVERYTHING

Add the cooked rice-dal mixture to the vegetables, along with the spice powder, jaggery, and salt. Mix thoroughly, adding water as needed to reach a thick, porridge-like consistency.



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Bringing It All Together, continued

Texture indicator. bisibele bath should be thick and slightly wet, closer to a hearty porridge than separate, fluffy rice grains.

06 SIMMER TO MELD

Simmer everything together for 10 minutes, stirring occasionally, to let the flavors fully combine.

07 ADD THE FINAL TEMPERING

Heat ghee in a small pan, add mustard seeds, letting them pop, then curry leaves, asafoetida, and cashews, frying until the cashews turn golden. Pour over the finished bisibele bath.

MISTAKE TO AVOID

Cooking the rice and dal to a normal, fluffy texture rather than a soft, slightly mushy one misses what makes bisibele bath distinct from plain sambar rice. Let them cook down further than you might for a standard rice dish.

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SERVING & PAIRING

How to serve



Traditional Style

- Served hot with a generous drizzle of ghee, plain yogurt, and papad or potato chips on the side.
- A festival and celebration staple across Karnataka, alongside everyday family lunches.

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How to serve, continued

Restaurant Presentation

- Served in a bowl topped with fried cashews and a visible pool of ghee, papad alongside.

Family Style

- A hearty, complete one-pot meal, often the only dish needed for a satisfying lunch.

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RESTAURANT-GRADE TRICKS

Chef secrets

Getting the Texture Right

- Cooking the rice and dal softer than usual is essential — bisibele bath should have a distinctly hearty, slightly porridge-like consistency.
- The dedicated spice powder, rather than a generic sambar powder, is what gives this dish its signature warmth and depth.

Make-Ahead & Meal Prep

- The spice powder can be made in a large batch and stored airtight for months.
- Bisibele bath reheats well with added water, making it a practical make-ahead lunch option.

RESTAURANT TRICK

Some Mysore restaurants add a small piece of ghee-fried onion on top as an additional garnish alongside the cashews, for extra aroma and visual appeal.

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BONUS CONTENT

Nutrition, variations & FAQ

APPROXIMATE NUTRITION, PER SERVING

310 kcal	10 g	48 g	9 g	7 g
CALORIES	PROTEIN	CARBOHYDRATES	FAT	FIBER

Estimates only; actual values vary with oil and portion size.

ALLERGEN GUIDE

Contains, based on the ingredient list: Dairy, Gluten, Tree nuts, Mustard. Check packaged spices and asafoetida, which may contain wheat, and verify against your own ingredients.

REGIONAL VARIATIONS

Mysore-Style Bisibele Bath	the classic, richly spiced version featured here.
Vegetable-Heavy Bisibele Bath	some households add extra vegetables for a more substantial, nutrient-dense dish.
Millet Bisibele Bath	a modern, health-conscious variation using millets instead of rice.

Can I make this less spicy?

Yes — reduce the dried red chilies in the spice powder, or use fewer store-bought spoons if using a pre-made blend.

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Nutrition, variations & FAQ, continued

Why is my bisibele bath too thick or too thin?

Adjust with water — the dish thickens as it sits, so add water gradually while reheating to restore your preferred consistency.

Is this the same as sambar rice?

No — while related, bisibele bath uses a distinct spice powder and a softer, more porridge-like rice-dal texture, giving it a different character from simple sambar mixed with rice.

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REFERENCE

Ingredient glossary



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REFERENCE

Ingredient glossary, continued

GLOSSARY

Bisi Bele Bath	Kannada for "hot lentil rice," the literal translation of this dish's name.
Iyengar	a South Indian Brahmin community credited in food tradition with refining this dish.
Sona Masoori	a popular short-grain rice variety used in Karnataka cooking.
Tadka	a tempering of spices bloomed in hot ghee, added to finish this dish.

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PRINTABLE RECIPE CARD

Bisibele Bath

20m	40m
ACTIVE PREP	COOK TIME
6	Med
SERVINGS	DIFFICULTY

RICE AND DAL

Rice	200 g
Toor dal	100 g
Water	1 L
Turmeric powder	1.5 g

VEGETABLES & TAMARIND

Tamarind	30 g
Carrot	60 g
Green beans	50 g
Potato	80 g
Peas	70 g
Small onion	80 g

BISIBELE BATH POWDER (OR 3 TBSP STORE-BOUGHT)

Coriander seeds	12 g
Chana dal	12 g
Urad dal	10 g
Dried red chilies	5–6
Cinnamon stick	1 inch
Cloves	3
Desiccated coconut	12 g

TEMPERING & FINISH

Ghee	45 g
Mustard seeds	4 g
Curry leaves	15–20 leaves
Asafoetida	pinch
Cashews	35 g
Jaggery	5 g
Salt	9 g

METHOD

01 **Roast and grind the spice blend.** Dry roast the coriander seeds, chana dal, urad dal, dried chilies, cinnamon, cloves, and coconut in a pan until fragrant and golden, about 4–5 minutes.

02 **Cook the rice and dal together.** Rinse the rice and toor dal together and pressure cook with water and turmeric for 4–5 whistles, until both are very soft and slightly mushy — softer than you'd typically cook rice on its own.

03 **Prepare the tamarind extract.** Soak the tamarind in 1 cup / 240 ml warm water for 15 minutes, then squeeze and strain to extract the pulp.

04 **Cook the vegetables.** In a separate pot, cook the carrot, beans, potato, peas, and onion in the tamarind extract with a little water until just tender, about 10 minutes.

05 **Combine everything.** Add the cooked rice-dal mixture to the vegetables, along with the spice powder, jaggery, and salt.

06 **Simmer to meld.** Simmer everything together for 10 minutes, stirring occasionally, to let the flavors fully combine.

07 **Add the final tempering.** Heat ghee in a small pan, add mustard seeds, letting them pop, then curry leaves, asafoetida, and cashews, frying until the cashews turn golden.

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BEFORE YOU SHOP

Shopping list

☐ Rice	200 g	☐ Toor dal	100 g
☐ Turmeric powder	1.5 g	☐ Tamarind	30 g
☐ Carrot	60 g	☐ Green beans	50 g
☐ Potato	80 g	☐ Peas	70 g
☐ Small onion	80 g	☐ Coriander seeds	12 g
☐ Chana dal	12 g	☐ Urad dal	10 g
☐ Dried red chilies	5–6	☐ Cinnamon stick	1 inch
☐ Cloves	3	☐ Desiccated coconut	12 g
☐ Ghee	45 g	☐ Mustard seeds	4 g
☐ Curry leaves	15–20 leaves	☐ Asafoetida	pinch
☐ Cashews	35 g	☐ Jaggery	5 g
☐ Salt	9 g		

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